transfer to headquarters in Delhi before Rabuka criticised the ambassador for meddling in Fiji's internal affairs. On 1 November 1989, the Indian government hit back at Rabuka with a warning that it would not close its eyes to the absolute need to maintain full support for the human and political rights of all the people of the island nation including, of course, ethnic Indians. The Indian government prudently argued that India also stood for the many people of Fijian origin who supported democracy. On the controversy around Sreenivasan, the official record of the MEA observed:

The Fiji authorities have written to our Ambassador in Fiji, T.P. Sreenivasan, indicating their displeasure with his recent statements and actions and alleging apparent interference of the Indian government in Fiji's affairs. These pertain mainly to the Ambassador's efforts to calm the feelings of the people of Indian origin of that country, after some misguided Fijians had recently burnt a Sikh Gurdwara, a Muslim mosque and two Hindu temples. The government of India is surprised by what the Fijian regime has done. The government rejects these charges as totally baseless. Sreenivasan was trying merely to emphasize the need for measures for restoring inter-racial harmony in Fiji and showing respect for all religions. Principled opposition to racial discrimination, wherever it occurs, has been a constant feature of India's foreign policy. This cannot be deemed to constitute interference in the internal affairs of any country. The communication received from the Fijian authorities also conveys their decision that the Ambassador should leave Fiji by 3rd November 1989, and their view that India's future representation in Fiji should be at a lower level. This statement is not easy to understand, as the government of India had already announced its decision to transfer